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Dominance and defiance

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Kinship as Setting and Value • Relations to Other Descent Groups

Although mother's divorced husband, mother's brother, mother's sister's husband, and father's sister's husband are all *rawa*, there are significant differences in behavioral interactions reported in the tables and by informants in discussing kinship. Thus mother's brother and father's sister's husband are reported as having a similar relationship to Ego, but this is quite different to that with mother's divorced husband. In general, respect is high with all persons called *rawa*, while joking is low, and as would be expected from our discussion above, friendship and fondness responses are somewhat higher for mother's brother than the others. On the other hand a higher proportion (42%) report shame-avoidance relations with their mother's divorced husband than with all other persons termed *rawa*. Kanuri informants explain this by saying that it is shameful to have anything to do with a man who has had sexual relations with one's mother. The same in reverse is true for all relatives called *bawa* (father's sister, father's brother's wife, father's other wives, or father's divorced wife). However, besides increased shame with father's other wives, there is suppressed tension between Ego and such women which can be alleviated or enhanced by personality factors.²¹ There are formal joking relations between ego and his or her spouse's younger siblings. Ego jokes about who his spouse's younger sibling is going to marry, or have sexual relations with, or about possible affairs that the younger one should or might have. However, the younger person is still respectful toward the older sibling's spouse, as indicated in Table 4:2, while the joking is mostly directed toward the younger partner. However, it is impossible even in a joking manner to refer to spouse's younger sibling as "wife" or "little wife" as do the Hausa. Marriage with wife's younger sister is forbidden by custom unless the present wife (her sister) is dead. The sororate is possible but sororal polygyny is not. To even jokingly call wife's younger sister "wife" implies the death of one's present

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wife. Exactly the same conditions hold for a woman's relations to her husband's younger brother.

Kinship as Setting and Value

In summary, the Kanuri have what Dole (1969) has called a bifurcate generational system of kinship terminology. Such a system reflects a unilineal past in which local endogamy has blurred the distinctions between cross and parallel cousins. If we add Islam to this, which allows patrilineal parallel cousin marriage, the blurring is aided by Kanuri religion. Endogamy resulting from progressive sedentarism, and probably class stratification as well,²² have worked together with Islam to change the original Kanuri kinship system seven to eight centuries ago when these features began to appear in the society.

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The change was from a system that emphasized a we-they distinction to one in which generation levels and seniority are the primary means of distinguishing among relatives. The complexity and regularity of the parent generation distinctions among kin reflect the early system, while all other generations reflect the more recent values.

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Given the accuracy of this reconstruction and therefore the correctness of my thesis that the present system reflects a unilineal past, what kind of unilineality was it? Unequivocally the answer has to be patrilineal. The people say that agnatic kin are the most important among all kin. Patrilineal kin give a man his place in society, his most important rights to fixed property; they must help a man with his bridewealth, and agnates are mutually responsible for one another in legal disputes. Indeed, in court the agnatic group is a corporate entity. In practice, people do  51 obtain help from matri-kin for bridewealth, for rights to land, and even for court fines. The obligation to help is more voluntary on the matrilineal side and more compulsory among agnates.

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Elsewhere (Cohen and Schlegel 1968) I have suggested that growing socio-political complexity is associated with the loss of clan exogamy.

Prevailing winds come from the east and northeast, bringing sand into any opening facing that direction.

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